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Nightmare Eclipse — Chaotic Eclipse Threat Actor Profile

Threat Actor Profile

Classification	TLP:CLEAR
Published	2026-06-10
Version	1.1
Author	Lost Boys Cyber
Report Type	Threat Actor Profile

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1. Executive Summary

Nightmare Eclipse, also referred to publicly as Chaotic Eclipse and Dead Eclipse, is best assessed as a threat-enablement actor: a hostile disclosure persona whose main operational value is accelerating real-world exploitation by publishing weaponizable Windows proof-of-concept (PoC) code. Available reporting does not support treating the persona as a classic espionage cluster or ransomware affiliate with a stable victim set. Instead, the actor repeatedly releases post-disclosure or zero-day exploit tooling that compresses defender patch windows and lowers the engineering burden for opportunistic intrusion operators.

Between April and June 2026, open-source reporting tied Nightmare Eclipse to BlueHammer, RedSun, UnDefend, YellowKey, GreenPlasma, and MiniPlasma. The most important defensive fact is that BlueHammer, RedSun, and UnDefend were not merely public demonstrations: Huntress documented their use in a live intrusion following likely FortiGate SSL VPN compromise. That observed chain turns Nightmare Eclipse from a curiosity into a practical enterprise risk, because the actor's disclosures are already being consumed by third parties.

The actor's exploit portfolio is strategically notable because it repeatedly abuses trusted Windows security and recovery components rather than attacking from an external perimeter alone. Public reporting links the tooling to Defender impairment, SYSTEM-level privilege escalation, SAM access, WinRE/BitLocker bypass behavior, and cloud-file race-condition abuse. These are defender-relevant trust-boundary failures, not isolated lab tricks.

From a defensive standpoint, organizations should treat new Nightmare Eclipse disclosures as early-warning indicators for follow-on copycat exploitation. The highest-priority actions are to deploy current Microsoft security updates, validate YellowKey-related WinRE mitigations, review Defender health and tamper telemetry, hunt for public-tool execution from user-writable paths, and correlate suspicious Windows privilege-escalation artifacts with remote-access logons.

Executive Judgment	Assessment
Actor characterization	Rogue disclosure / threat-enablement actor
Immediate enterprise relevance	High
Attribution confidence	Medium
Confidence that public tooling has enabled real intrusion activity	High
Most likely near-term risk	Opportunistic third-party exploitation of published PoCs

2. Intelligence Requirement

This profile addresses the following intelligence requirement: Who is Nightmare Eclipse, how has the actor's disclosure activity translated into enterprise risk, and what should defenders do now?

Intelligence Question	Current Answer	Confidence
Is Nightmare Eclipse a traditional intrusion set?	Current evidence better supports a rogue disclosure persona or malicious researcher profile than a stable espionage, ransomware, or financially motivated	Medium

	cluster.	
Has the actor's tooling translated into real-world victim risk?	Yes. Huntress documented BlueHammer, RedSun, and UnDefend in an active intrusion after suspected FortiGate SSL VPN compromise.	High
Which disclosures matter most now?	BlueHammer, RedSun, and UnDefend matter because they are linked to live intrusion activity; YellowKey and MiniPlasma matter because they expand risk into BitLocker/WinRE abuse and repeatable privilege-escalation chains.	High
What should defenders expect next?	Further copycat use by unrelated operators after each public disclosure, especially where the PoCs reduce exploit-development effort or bypass trusted Windows controls.	Medium

Assumption: this report focuses on defender impact and observable tradecraft rather than attempting personal attribution of the operator behind the Nightmare Eclipse aliases, which remains incompletely verified in open sources.

3. Source Review and Confidence

The source base is sufficient to support a practical threat-actor profile, but not strong enough to support high-confidence personal attribution. Confidence is highest where reporting includes intrusion artifacts, exploit mechanics, and concrete detection opportunities.

Source	Primary Contribution	Confidence	Notes
Huntress intrusion investigation (2026-04-20)	Strongest evidence that public Nightmare Eclipse tooling was used in a live intrusion; provides staging paths, follow-on activity, and tunnel infrastructure.	High	Best operational source in the corpus.
LevelBlue SpiderLabs YellowKey / MiniPlasma analysis	Detailed exploit mechanics, named pipe / registry / WinRE artifacts, and hunting opportunities.	High	Strong technical grounding for detection content.
ThreatLocker YellowKey / GreenPlasma analysis and 2026-06-10 update	Useful defensive framing and patch-state context for YellowKey and GreenPlasma.	Medium	Vendor analysis; patch wording should be checked against Microsoft guidance when available.
Barracuda actor profile	Good synthesis of aliases, publication tempo, and campaign narrative.	Medium	Motive and identity inferences remain only partly verified.
The Hacker News / F5 Labs coverage	Timeline support, CVE references, takedown context, and broad defender impact framing.	Medium	Secondary reporting; best used for chronology and corroboration.
Internal analytic assessment	Normalizes the actor as a	Medium	Assessment layer built on the

	threat-enablement profile rather than a personality-driven narrative.		above sources.
Confidence Area		Assessment	
Identity of the operator(s) behind the persona		Medium-Low	
Characterization as a disclosure-driven threat-enablement actor		Medium-High	
Confidence in exploit-to-intrusion translation		High	
Confidence in defender-relevant detection opportunities		High	

4.1 Actor Profile

Nightmare Eclipse appears to operate as a single persona or tightly controlled identity using public blogs and code repositories to release exploit tooling at a pace designed to pressure defenders and increase Microsoft-related public controversy. The actor's own messaging frames the campaign as retaliation over an alleged dispute with Microsoft's vulnerability-handling process. Even if that narrative is sincere, the operational outcome is indistinguishable from hostile capability release: public exploit availability, faster downstream weaponization, and lower barriers for commodity or opportunistic actors.

Attribute	Assessment
Primary aliases	Nightmare Eclipse, Chaotic Eclipse, Dead Eclipse
Assessed actor type	Rogue vulnerability-disclosure / threat-enablement actor
Apparent motive	Public grievance messaging against Microsoft; no verified profit motive
Operational model	Publish exploit PoCs and technical writeups via public platforms, often near Patch Tuesday timing
Defensive significance	Supplies dangerous capability to unrelated intrusion operators

4.2 Exploit Portfolio and Operational Relevance

The exploit set repeatedly targets trusted Windows control paths, especially where a local or post-compromise foothold can be amplified into SYSTEM privilege, credential access, or security-control weakening.

Tool / Disclosure	Assessed Function	Operational Relevance	Status / Notes
BlueHammer	Defender/VSS-assisted privilege escalation with SAM access path	High	Patched as CVE-2026-33825 in reporting; used in real intrusion activity.
RedSun	Defender-linked privilege escalation using cloud-file / TOCTOU behavior	High	Secondary reporting associates it with CVE-2026-41091; used in real intrusion activity.
UnDefend	Defender disruption and update/signature interference	High	Secondary reporting associates it with CVE-2026-45498; used in real intrusion activity.
YellowKey	BitLocker / WinRE bypass affecting TPM-only configurations	High	Publicly tracked as CVE-2026-45585; especially relevant for seized or briefly accessed

			devices.
GreenPlasma	CTFMON-related local privilege escalation concept	Medium-High	ThreatLocker reported June patch coverage as CVE-2026-45586.
MiniPlasma	Cloud Files driver race-condition privilege escalation revival	High	Strong chaining value with post-compromise tradecraft; detection opportunities well documented.

4.3 Observed Tradecraft and Intrusion Translation

The most consequential reporting comes from Huntress, which documented a real intrusion chain in which suspected FortiGate SSL VPN compromise was followed by use of BlueHammer, RedSun, and UnDefend from user-writable paths. The intrusion reportedly included SYSTEM-level privilege escalation, SAM access, credential-related actions, Defender interference, reconnaissance commands such as `whoami /priv`, `cmdkey /list`, and `net group`, and a Go-based Yamux reverse tunnel agent described as BeigeBurrow.

Phase	Observed or Assessed Technique	Evidence Basis
Capability delivery	Public PoC hosting on GitHub/GitLab and related blogs	THN, F5 Labs, Barracuda
Privilege escalation	Exploitation for Privilege Escalation via BlueHammer, RedSun, GreenPlasma, MiniPlasma	Huntress, ThreatLocker, LevelBlue
Defense evasion	Defender disruption and signature/update interference via UnDefend	Huntress
Credential access	SAM acquisition and follow-on credential-related activity	Huntress
Discovery	`whoami /priv`, `cmdkey /list`, `net group`	Huntress
Follow-on access support	Reverse tunnel activity to `staybud.dpdns[.]org:443`	Huntress
Physical-access abuse	WinRE / BitLocker bypass through YellowKey	ThreatLocker, LevelBlue

4.4 Infrastructure, Victimology, and Exposure

Nightmare Eclipse is better understood as an ecosystem risk multiplier than a narrowly targeted actor. The actor's disclosures mainly threaten organizations that rely heavily on Windows-native trust assumptions, have uneven patching, or expose remote-access surfaces that can feed a post-compromise privilege-escalation chain.

Indicator / Artifact	Type	Relevance
78.29.48[.]29	IP	Suspicious FortiGate SSL VPN source in Huntress reporting
212.232.23[.]69	IP	Additional suspicious VPN-session infrastructure in Huntress reporting
179.43.140[.]214	IP	Additional suspicious VPN-session infrastructure in Huntress reporting

staybud.dpdns[.]org:443	Domain / C2	Huntress-attributed reverse tunnel endpoint
`C:\Users\<user>\Pictures\FunnyApp.exe`	File path pattern	BlueHammer staging path
`C:\Users\<user>\Downloads\RedSun.exe`	File path pattern	RedSun execution artifact
`C:\Users\<user>\Downloads\ks\undef.exe`	File path pattern	UnDefend artifact
`MiniPlasmaWERPipe`	Named pipe	MiniPlasma-related artifact described by LevelBlue
`autofstx.exe` in WinRE `BootExecute`	Boot / registry artifact	Central YellowKey exploitation dependency
Exposure Cluster		Why It Matters
Remote-access-heavy enterprises and MSPs		Public PoCs are easiest to operationalize after stolen or weakly protected remote-access credentials.
Laptop-heavy organizations using TPM-only BitLocker		YellowKey raises risk from stolen, seized, or briefly accessed endpoints.
Windows-centric enterprises with slow patch cycles		Disclosure timing compresses mitigation windows and enables copycat use.
Teams that over-trust native security components		Defender, WinRE, Cloud Files, and recovery paths are explicit abuse targets.

4.5 MITRE ATT&CK Mapping

The ATT&CK mapping below reflects how Nightmare Eclipse tooling appears in intrusion chains rather than implying the persona is a conventional ATT&CK intrusion set.

ATT&CK ID	Technique	Why It Fits
T1587.001	Develop Capabilities: Malware	Public development and release of operational exploit tooling.
T1588.005	Obtain Capabilities: Exploits	Disclosed PoCs enable follow-on actors to obtain exploits cheaply.
T1068	Exploitation for Privilege Escalation	BlueHammer, RedSun, GreenPlasma, and MiniPlasma all center on SYSTEM-level escalation.
T1562.001	Impair Defenses	UnDefend focuses on degrading Defender protections.
T1003.002	Security Account Manager	Huntress linked BlueHammer activity to SAM access.
T1033	System Owner/User Discovery	`whoami /priv` and related commands support user / privilege discovery.
T1082	System Information Discovery	Follow-on reconnaissance behavior supports host enumeration.
T1555	Credentials from Password Stores	`cmdkey /list` activity indicates interest in

		credential material.
T1059.003	Windows Command Shell	Observed command usage occurred through standard Windows shell execution.
T1133	External Remote Services	Huntress tied the intrusion to suspicious SSL VPN access.
T1572	Protocol Tunneling	BeigeBurrow reverse tunneling aligns with protocol tunneling behavior.
T1200	Hardware Additions	YellowKey's physical-access implications map to hardware-adjacent attack conditions.

5. Threat Context

Nightmare Eclipse matters less because of a known victim count directly attributable to the persona and more because of the actor's role in the broader Windows exploitation ecosystem. Each disclosure creates an asymmetric burden: a single public release can arm many unrelated operators, while defenders must validate patch levels, test mitigations, and hunt for artifacts across large fleets. That asymmetry is particularly acute when the actor targets security controls that defenders normally trust, such as Defender, WinRE, and Cloud Files behavior.

The operational pattern also creates a decision problem for security teams. Some public disclosures may look like research drama or proof-of-concept theater, but the Huntress case shows that at least part of the portfolio translated into hands-on intrusion activity. Defenders should therefore avoid dismissing future Nightmare Eclipse releases as purely academic. Even imperfect PoCs can serve as reference implementations that shorten exploit-development cycles for other actors.

Risk Dimension	Assessment
Likelihood of direct attack by the persona against any given enterprise	Medium-Low
Likelihood of third-party reuse after disclosure	High
Potential impact if exploitation succeeds	High
Priority for Windows-centric enterprises	High
Priority for organizations with strong physical-device controls but weak remote access	High, because risk spans both post-compromise and physical-access scenarios

Analytic judgment: For most organizations, the most likely scenario is not bespoke targeting by Nightmare Eclipse. It is opportunistic or follow-on abuse by unrelated actors who consume the published tooling. This makes the profile immediately relevant to vulnerability management, endpoint engineering, SOC operations, DFIR, and remote-access owners.

6. Detection and Hunting

This actor profile supports behavior-based detection engineering rather than signature-only coverage. The most defensible approach is to combine endpoint telemetry, Defender health events, VPN telemetry, and artifact-driven hunts around public-tool staging from user-writable paths.

Detection Focus	Telemetry Source	Analytic Goal
Tool execution from `Downloads`, `Pictures`, or temp paths	EDR process telemetry, Sysmon, Defender alerts	Surface likely BlueHammer / RedSun / UnDefend copycat use
Defender service failures or signature-	Windows event logs, Defender operational	Detect UnDefend-style impairment activity

engine anomalies	logs, EDR	
Cloud Files API abuse from unexpected processes	EDR advanced telemetry, ETW, API telemetry	Detect RedSun / MiniPlasma exploitation patterns
WinRE `BootExecute` anomalies or `autofstx.exe` presence	Offline registry review, DFIR collection, recovery telemetry	Detect or validate YellowKey exposure
Named pipe `MiniPlasmaWERPipe` or suspicious `wermgr.exe` execution	EDR process / pipe telemetry	Detect MiniPlasma-related activity
Suspicious VPN logons followed by Windows privilege-escalation artifacts	VPN logs plus endpoint telemetry	Correlate initial access with exploit staging

6.1 Sigma Analytic

```

title: Suspicious Nightmare Eclipse Tool Execution From User-Writable Paths
id: 2d6fa57f-92fc-49f7-9f70-59be1d3f0d90
status: experimental
logsource:
  category: process_creation
  product: windows
detection:
  selection_img:
    Image|endswith:
      - '\\FunnyApp.exe'
      - '\\RedSun.exe'
      - '\\undef.exe'
      - '\\z.exe'
      - '\\agent.exe'
  selection_path:
    Image|contains:
      - '\\Users\\'
      - '\\Downloads\\'
      - '\\Pictures\\'
      - '\\Temp\\'
  selection_cmd:
    CommandLine|contains:
      - 'whoami /priv'
      - 'cmdkey /list'
      - 'net group'
      - '-server staybud.dpdns.org:443 -hide'
  condition: (selection_img and selection_path) or selection_cmd
falsepositives:
  - Administrator testing of public PoCs in a lab
  - Internal red-team validation using copied filenames
level: high

```

6.2 Microsoft Defender XDR Hunt

```

let SuspiciousToolNames = dynamic(["FunnyApp.exe", "RedSun.exe", "undef.exe", "z.exe", "agent.exe"]);
let SuspiciousCmdTerms = dynamic(["whoami /priv", "cmdkey /list", "net
group", "staybud.dpdns.org:443", "MiniPlasmaWERPipe"]);
DeviceProcessEvents
| where Timestamp > ago(30d)
| where FileName in~ (SuspiciousToolNames)
  or ProcessCommandLine has_any (SuspiciousCmdTerms)
  or (FolderPath has @"\\Users\\" and FolderPath has_any (@\\"Downloads\\", @\\"Pictures\\", @\\"Temp\\
\\") and FileName in~ (SuspiciousToolNames))
| project Timestamp, DeviceName, AccountName, FileName, FolderPath, ProcessCommandLine,
InitiatingProcessFileName, InitiatingProcessCommandLine
| order by Timestamp desc

```

6.3 Correlation Hunt for Remote Access + Public PoC Usage

```
let vpn_window = 14d;
let suspicious_ips = dynamic(["78.29.48.29", "212.232.23.69", "179.43.140.214"]);
let suspicious_files = dynamic(["FunnyApp.exe", "RedSun.exe", "undef.exe", "z.exe", "agent.exe"]);
union isfuzzy=true
(
DeviceLogonEvents
| where Timestamp > ago(vpn_window)
| where RemoteIP in (suspicious_ips)
| project Timestamp, DeviceName, AccountName, RemoteIP, Indicator="Suspicious remote logon"
),
(
DeviceProcessEvents
| where Timestamp > ago(vpn_window)
| where FileName in~ (suspicious_files)
    or ProcessCommandLine has_any ("whoami /priv", "cmdkey /list", "net
group", "MiniPlasmaWERPipe", "staybud.dpdns.org:443")
| project Timestamp, DeviceName, AccountName, RemoteIP="", Indicator=strcat("Process: ", FileName)
)
| order by Timestamp desc
```

6.4 Additional Hunt Leads

Hunt Lead	Why It Matters
Unscheduled WinRE boots on Windows 11 / Server 2022+	Could indicate YellowKey staging, validation, or exploitation attempts.
Non-standard `wermgr.exe` execution paths	LevelBlue linked this behavior to MiniPlasma technique flow.
Registry symbolic-link abuse under `.DEFAULT\Software\Policies\Microsoft\CloudFiles\BlockedApp s`	MiniPlasma-specific redirect behavior.
Defender EICAR or signature events immediately followed by unusual file-system or COM activity	Huntress described EICAR-linked behavior during RedSun setup.
Public-PoC filenames appearing on servers or admin workstations	Suggests testing, copycat intrusion activity, or unsafe internal handling of released tooling.

7. Recommendations

Recommendations are prioritized for enterprise defenders that need to reduce both immediate exposure and repeat operational burden from future Nightmare Eclipse disclosures.

Priority	Owner	Recommendation	Defensive Effect
Critical	Vulnerability management	Deploy the latest Microsoft security updates across supported Windows clients and servers; verify coverage for YellowKey, GreenPlasma, and other disclosed issues relevant to your estate.	Shrinks exploitation window and reduces copycat reuse value.
Critical	Endpoint engineering	Validate YellowKey mitigation by inspecting WinRE `BootExecute` handling and implementing Microsoft's recommended fix where	Reduces physical-access BitLocker bypass exposure.

		patching is incomplete.	
High	IAM / remote-access owners	Review FortiGate and other VPN logs for unusual geographies, impossible travel, and credential reuse; enforce phishing-resistant MFA wherever feasible.	Disrupts the most plausible post-compromise path into public LPE tooling use.
High	SOC / detection engineering	Deploy analytics for `FunnyApp.exe`, `RedSun.exe`, `undef.exe`, suspicious `agent.exe`, Defender anomalies, and `MiniPlasmaWERPipe`.	Improves detection of public-tool execution and follow-on activity.
High	Endpoint hardening	Move sensitive laptop populations from TPM-only BitLocker to TPM+PIN where operationally feasible, and protect firmware / boot settings.	Mitigates YellowKey-style physical-access abuse.
High	DFIR / threat hunting	Hunt for user-writable execution of exploit tools, non-standard `wermgr.exe`, WinRE anomalies, and suspicious Cloud Files API behavior.	Finds both active exploitation and unsafe internal testing.
Medium	Security leadership	Pre-stage Patch Tuesday communications, rapid validation playbooks, and business-owner expectations for future public exploit drops.	Improves resilience against repeated disclosure-driven patch stress.
Medium	Security awareness / engineering governance	Prohibit unsanctioned internal testing of public PoCs on production systems and require lab controls for exploit validation.	Prevents self-inflicted false positives and accidental exposure.

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